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PODCAST

AMONG THE FAITHFUL AND THE FORGOTTEN, THE GAME CARRIES ON

Our reporters bring vignettes from across India's domestic season, moments that unfold **beyond the scoreboard.**

The evening air at the Sawai Mansingh Stadium crackled with excitement as play ended on the first day of the Ranji Trophy round-three fixture. Outside the Mumbai dressing room, a crowd waited for one man — Yashasvi Jaiswal.

He may have been wearing Mumbai colours, but in Jaipur, Jaiswal is still the local hero. Years of representing Rajasthan Royals have earned him that affection, and his return to the venue drew hundreds of fans. Even after his dismissal before lunch, they stayed on, hoping for a glimpse or selfie with their "Yash bhaiya."

As daylight faded and security relaxed, the crowd thickened. When Jaiswal finally stepped out, phones flashed and chants erupted. He smiled and posed for a few pictures, but the growing frenzy forced Mumbai's management to change plans.

While Shardul Thakur and Ajinkya Rahane boarded the team bus to loud chants, Jaiswal quietly slipped away toward the RCA Academy end with bowling coach Dhawal Kulkarni and manager Bhushan Patil. But their escape hit a snag — the alternate gate was locked, the staff gone for the day.

Word spread fast. Fans sprinted from the main



entrance, their footsteps echoing through the corridors. The trio rushed toward the north gate, only to find another mob waiting. Eventually, Jaiswal turned back towards the dressing room, where a car awaited. Local volunteers helped him reach it safely, and he managed a few more quick selfies before leaving.

As his car rolled out into the Jaipur night, chants trailed behind: "Humara bhai kaisa ho, Yash bhaiya jaisa ho."

Shayan Acharya

COMFORT OFF THE FIELD, CONCERN ON IT

You often find yourself thrust into unique environments and circumstances while covering domestic cricket in India. Some can be exasperating, like balancing your laptop and notebook while precariously sitting on the parapet of an under-construction building at the Sanosara Cricket Ground B in Rajkot. The quaint CAP Ground 2 in Puducherry, on the other hand, threw open the doors of a room in its residential quarters overlooking the ground. The two cozy single beds in the room were tantalising propositions for a post-prandial snooze, especially considering that no play was possible in three sessions over the last two days due to a persistent drizzle caused by the depression that had settled over the Bay of Bengal as cyclone Montha was building up.

These were welcome off-the-field home comforts for the Diary, who was born and raised in the Union Territory, but the host team didn't find it easy on the field. The elements had to conspire to save Pondicherry from an outright defeat after Hyderabad took a mammoth first-innings lead.

A common grouse amongst the locals here has been the conspicuous lack of homegrown talent, particularly in red-ball cricket; the XI against Hyderabad didn't feature a single local player. Ironically, the only player whose name hinted at a local identity, the debutant off-spinner Karan